



PIRLS Reading Practice — Year 5

Providence English Private School

Set 1: The Lighthouse Keeper's Daughter

Literary Text · 14 Questions · 40 Minutes

Name: _____ Class: _____ Date: _____

The Lighthouse Keeper's Daughter

Mara had lived at Sandpoint Lighthouse for as long as she could remember. Her father was the keeper, and every evening at dusk he climbed the one hundred and twelve spiral steps to light the great lamp that warned ships away from the rocks below.

Tonight, the wind was different. It didn't just blow — it howled, rattling the shutters and flinging salt spray against the windows. Mara's father pulled on his coat, his face tight with worry.

"The forecast didn't mention this," he muttered, checking the barometer on the wall. The needle had dropped sharply since morning. "I need to check the lamp mechanism before the storm gets worse. Stay here, Mara, and keep watch out the window. If you see any ship's lights moving strangely, ring the bell straight away."

Mara nodded, though her stomach felt tight. She had never been left on watch alone before, not during a proper storm.

Her father disappeared up the spiral staircase, and Mara pressed her face to the cold glass. Rain lashed sideways across the bay. For a long while, she saw nothing but grey waves crashing against black rocks.

Then, out past the point, she spotted it: a small light, bobbing unevenly, moving far too close to the reef.

Mara's heart thudded. A fishing boat. It had to be the Hendersons — they were the only ones who went out this late, and everyone in the village knew they sometimes cut it close, chasing one last catch before a storm.

She grabbed the bell rope with both hands and pulled with all her strength. The bell's clang cut through the wind, sharp and urgent. She rang it again and again, not stopping, even as her arms began to ache.

Above her, she heard her father's boots pounding back down the stairs. He burst into the room, saw her at the window, and followed her pointing finger out to sea.

"Good girl," he said, already moving to the radio. "That's exactly right. That's Henderson's boat, sailing blind in this." He spoke quickly into the radio, calling the coastguard, giving the boat's position as precisely as Mara had shown him.

While they waited, Mara didn't leave the window. She kept her eyes fixed on that small, stubborn light, willing it to stay above the water. Twice it seemed to vanish behind a wave, and both times her breath caught until it reappeared.

It felt like hours, though her father later said it was only twenty minutes, before the coastguard boat appeared, its searchlight sweeping the bay until it found the smaller vessel. Mara watched, still gripping the windowsill, as the two boats drew together and a line was thrown across.

Only when both boats turned safely back toward harbour did Mara let out the breath she'd been holding.

Her father crossed the room and put a hand on her shoulder. "You did well tonight," he said quietly. "Better than well. If you hadn't kept watching — hadn't rung that bell when you did — things might have gone very differently."

Mara looked back out at the dark water, calmer now that the boats were safe, and felt something she hadn't expected: not just relief, but a quiet kind of pride. She understood, in a way she hadn't before, why her father loved this strange, lonely job. Someone had to watch the water. Tonight, that someone had been her.

Questions

1. MULTIPLE CHOICE · RETRIEVE

Where does Mara live?

- ☐ A In a fishing village
- ☐ B At a lighthouse
- ☐ C On a boat
- ☐ D In a coastguard station

2. MULTIPLE CHOICE · RETRIEVE

What was unusual about the wind on this particular night?

- ☐ A It stopped completely
- ☐ B It changed direction constantly
- ☐ C It howled and rattled the shutters, unlike the forecast
- ☐ D It smelled of salt for the first time

3. WRITTEN RESPONSE · INFER

Why did Mara's father check the barometer?

4. MULTIPLE CHOICE · RETRIEVE

What job did Mara's father give her while he checked the lamp?

- ☐ A To ring the coastguard
- ☐ B To watch for ships and ring the bell if needed
- ☐ C To fix the lamp mechanism herself
- ☐ D To go and warn the village

5. WRITTEN RESPONSE · INTERPRET & INTEGRATE

How do you think Mara felt while she was alone at the window, before she saw the light? Use evidence from the passage.

6. MULTIPLE CHOICE · RETRIEVE

Why did Mara guess the boat belonged to the Hendersons?

- ☐ A She recognised the boat's shape
- ☐ B They were the only ones who went out that late, chasing one last catch
- ☐ C Her father told her on the radio
- ☐ D She saw their name painted on the hull

7. MULTIPLE CHOICE · INTERPRET & INTEGRATE

What does the phrase 'her breath caught' suggest about how Mara felt when the light vanished behind a wave?

- ☐ A She was bored
- ☐ B She was suddenly frightened or worried
- ☐ C She was laughing
- ☐ D She was falling asleep

8. WRITTEN RESPONSE · EVALUATE

Do you think Mara's father was right to leave her alone at the window during the storm? Explain your thinking.

9. MULTIPLE CHOICE · RETRIEVE

How long did the rescue actually take, according to Mara's father?

- A Two hours
- B About twenty minutes
- C All night
- D Five minutes

10. MULTIPLE CHOICE · INTERPRET & INTEGRATE

What is the best description of how Mara feels at the very end of the story?

- A Angry that she had to work so hard
- B Frightened and wanting to leave the lighthouse
- C Proud and beginning to understand her father's job
- D Confused about what happened

11. WRITTEN RESPONSE · EVALUATE

What does this story suggest about the importance of paying close attention, even when a task feels ordinary (like 'keeping watch')? Support your answer with an example from the story.

12. MULTIPLE CHOICE · INTERPRET & INTEGRATE

What word best describes Mara's father's tone when he says 'Good girl... That's exactly right'?

- A Angry
- B Approving and relieved
- C Sarcastic
- D Indifferent

13. MULTIPLE CHOICE · RETRIEVE

Which sentence from the story best shows that the rescue was successful?

- A "The forecast didn't mention this," he muttered.
- B Only when both boats turned safely back toward harbour did Mara let out the breath she'd been holding.
- C Mara had lived at Sandpoint Lighthouse for as long as she could remember.
- D Rain lashed sideways across the bay.

14. WRITTEN RESPONSE · EVALUATE

If you were Mara, what would you have found most difficult about that night? Explain why.

Answer Key & Model Answers

1. B — At a lighthouse

The passage states directly that Mara lived at Sandpoint Lighthouse.

2. C — It howled and rattled the shutters, unlike the forecast

The text says the wind 'didn't just blow — it howled' and that the forecast hadn't mentioned this.

3. Written response

Model answer: He was checking the barometer because a dropping needle signals worsening weather, so he wanted to see how serious the storm was becoming before deciding what to do.

Marking guidance: Full credit: explains that the barometer helps predict how bad the storm will get / that a falling reading signals a storm is worsening.

Partial credit: just says he wanted to check the weather, without explaining why a barometer helps.

4. B — To watch for ships and ring the bell if needed

He told her to keep watch out the window and ring the bell if she saw a ship's lights moving strangely.

5. Written response

Model answer: Mara likely felt nervous and unsure of herself, since the text says her stomach felt tight and that she had never been left on watch alone during a proper storm before.

Marking guidance: Full credit: identifies nervousness/anxiety AND references the textual evidence (tight stomach, first time alone in a storm). Partial credit: identifies the feeling but doesn't support it with the text.

6. B — They were the only ones who went out that late, chasing one last catch

The passage explains that the Hendersons were known for sailing late and cutting it close before a storm.

7. B — She was suddenly frightened or worried

'Her breath caught' is an expression showing a sudden feeling of fear or worry, matching her concern for the boat's safety.

8. Written response

Model answer: Answers will vary, but a strong response might argue he was right because there was no one else to keep watch and it turned out to matter greatly, or that it was a difficult decision because storms can be dangerous for a child to face alone — while also noting Mara proved capable.

Marking guidance: Full credit: gives a clear opinion supported by a reason drawn from the text (e.g., urgency of the situation, Mara's proven capability, or the risk involved). Partial credit: gives an opinion with little or no supporting reason.

9. B — About twenty minutes

The passage states it was only twenty minutes, even though it felt like hours to Mara.

10. C — Proud and beginning to understand her father's job

The final paragraph describes her feeling 'a quiet kind of pride' and beginning to understand why her father loved the job.

11. Written response

Model answer: The story suggests that paying close attention can matter enormously, even in a task that seems routine — Mara's careful watching and quick action directly led to the fishing boat being found and rescued.

Marking guidance: Full credit: states the idea (attention/vigilance matters) and connects it to a specific story example (spotting the light, ringing the bell). Partial credit: states the idea without a specific example.

12. B — Approving and relieved

His words and actions (moving quickly to the radio, praising her) show approval and relief.

13. B — Only when both boats turned safely back toward harbour did Mara let out the breath she'd been holding.

This sentence directly shows both boats returning safely, confirming the rescue worked.

14. Written response

Model answer: Answers will vary — a thoughtful response might mention the fear of being alone in a storm for the first time, the pressure of an important responsibility, or the anxious waiting to see if the boat would be found in time.

Marking guidance: Full credit: names a specific difficulty and explains why, connecting to feelings or events in the story. Partial credit: names a difficulty with little explanation.